

Little Beaver Creek watershed named Important Bird Area

Sunday, April 29, 2007

The IBA promotes key areas in Ohio critical to survival of birds.

ST. CLAIR — Audubon Ohio has designated the lower Little Beaver Creek watershed as an Important Bird Area.

John Ritzenthaler, director of habitat conservation for Audubon Ohio, will recognize the IBA for migrating and breeding birds at a dedication ceremony at 1:30 p.m. Saturday at the Beaver Creek Wildlife Education Center at Beaver Creek State Park.

The IBA program is the main conservation initiative of Audubon Ohio. Its main goal is to identify key areas in Ohio that are critical to the survival of birds, and to promote the conservation of these areas to maintain healthy bird populations.

The Little Beaver Creek IBA is one of 64 Ohio IBAs that have been identified. It is one of seven sites in Ohio providing nesting sites for birds that normally breed in Canada, such as the northern parula and the red-breasted nuthatch. It is also one of the top five breeding sites for the blue-headed vireo.

The IBA helps form a corridor that is a vital stopover link for migrating songbirds and essential habitat for breeding birds.

"Little Beaver Creek is a perfect example of the important role Ohio's landscape plays in the survival of birds," Ritzenthaler said.

Natural beauty

The watershed has long been known by those who love nature as the place to go in Columbiana County to see beautiful spring wildflowers, a wide variety of birds, scenic vistas and an increasingly wide variety of other animals. Deep hemlock gorges surround and protect Little Beaver Creek, providing nesting-site habitat for ducks, songbirds, woodpeckers, owls, hawks and many other birds. The habitat provides food, water and a safe area to raise their young. The diversity of the plant life and the rugged hills surrounding the Little Beaver Creek help to protect the nest sites from predators, as well as from curious hikers and others visiting the area.

This area has been protected over the years due to the foresight of the Vodrey Family Trust, and through the hard work of many conservation-minded groups such as the Little Beaver Creek Land Foundation, Columbiana County Federation of Conservation Clubs, Little Beaver Creek Wild and Scenic River Area Council and the Columbiana Soil & Water Conservation District.

